



TokyoExpat

YOUR JAPAN RELOCATION EXPERTS

2026 EDITION

Japan Relocation Checklist

Everything you need to do before, during, and after your move to Japan — from visa to bank account.

6

MONTHS BEFORE

90+

ACTION ITEMS

7

PHASES

0

ADMIN SURPRISES



PHASE 1

6 to 3 Months Before Arrival

- ☐ **Determine your visa type ★**
Working Holiday, HSP, Spouse, Student, or Business Manager
- ☐ **Start visa application ★**
Gather documents: bank statements, employment letter, CV
- ☐ **Research neighborhoods**
Shinjuku, Shibuya, Setagaya, Koto, Adachi by budget/lifestyle
- ☐ **Set your housing budget**
Tokyo average: 80,000-130,000 JPY/month for 1K/1LDK
- ☐ **Book temporary accommodation**
Monthly apartment or guesthouse for first 1-2 months
- ☐ **Notify your home country bank**
International transfers, notify of address change
- ☐ **Open a Wise account**
Mid-market rate with a visible fee, plus JPY account details. Best for regular transfers. For a one-off lump sum such as a property purchase, compare a dedicated FX broker too, and judge on the yen that actually land, not the advertised rate.
- ☐ **Sort out health insurance**
SafetyWing for transit period before National Health Insurance
- ☐ **Decide what to ship vs. sell**
Japan has strict customs rules. Electronics/furniture often not worth shipping
- ☐ **Get International Driving Permit**
Valid for 1 year in Japan. Required if you plan to drive



PHASE 2

1 to 2 Months Before Arrival

- ☐ **Book your flights ★**
One-way or round-trip depending on visa requirements
- ☐ **Arrange document apostilles**
Birth certificate, marriage certificate if applicable
- ☐ **Research Japanese language basics**
Hiragana, katakana, key phrases for daily life
- ☐ **Set up mail forwarding**
Notify all important services of your future absence
- ☐ **Cancel or transfer subscriptions**
Gym, streaming services, insurance policies
- ☐ **Scan all important documents**
Passport, diploma, birth certificate, store in cloud
- ☐ **Research SIM card options**
Sakura Mobile, IJmio, LINEMO — buy at airport or online
- ☐ **Download essential apps**
Google Maps, Google Translate, Hyperdia, Suica, LINE

Pro tip — Carry-on essentials

Pack your passport, all visa documents, temporary accommodation address, and 100,000 JPY cash in your carry-on. Japanese customs may ask for your address in Japan.



PHASE 3

First 48 Hours in Japan

**Register your address at the Ward Office (Shiyakusho) ★**

Bring passport + visa. You receive your Residence Card (Zairyu Card). Mandatory within 14 days but do it immediately.

**Get a SIM card ★**

Sakura Mobile and IJmio are foreigner-friendly. Airport counters available at Narita and Haneda.

**Get a Suica card (IC card)**

At any JR station or 7-Eleven ATM. Load 3,000-5,000 JPY. Works on trains, buses, convenience stores.

**Locate nearest convenience store, supermarket, and pharmacy**

7-Eleven and FamilyMart ATMs accept foreign cards. Matsumoto Kiyoshi for pharmacy.

**Check in to temporary accommodation**

Confirm check-in time in advance. Japanese guesthouses often have strict rules.

Important: Residence Card comes first

Without your Residence Card address, you cannot open a bank account, sign a lease, or register for National Health Insurance. Do this on Day 1.



PHASE 4

First 2 Weeks

**Open a Japanese bank account ★**

PayPay Bank or Sony Bank: 100% online, English UI, foreigner-friendly

**Start apartment search ★**

Use foreigner-friendly, bilingual agencies. Many of the best options never reach the big listing sites.

**Apply for National Health Insurance**

At your ward office. Required for all residents. ~5,000-20,000 JPY/month

**Apply for National Pension (Kokumin Nenkin)**

At ward office. Low income: apply for exemption (menjo)

**Set up PayPay or LINE Pay**

Cashless payment: essential for taxis, convenience stores, restaurants

**Explore your neighborhood on foot**

Find the closest station, post office, ward office, hospital



PHASE 5

First Month: Settle In

- ☐ **Sign your apartment lease ★**
Budget: 2-3 months deposit + agency fee. Key money (reikin) in some areas.
- ☐ **Set up electricity**
TEPCO in Tokyo: online signup, English available. Done in 1 day.
- ☐ **Set up gas**
Technician visit required. Tokyo Gas. Must be present (half-day).
- ☐ **Set up internet**
NURO Fiber or SoftBank Air. 2-4 week install delay is common.
- ☐ **Register new address at ward office**
Update your Residence Card address within 14 days of moving in.
- ☐ **Apply for My Number Card**
My Number is the ID number issued to every resident, foreign residents included, once you register your address. At ward office. Takes 3-6 weeks. Required for taxes, some banking.
- ☐ **Get a personal hanko (seal)**
Optional but useful. Convenience stores have machines (Shachihata).
- ☐ **Visit a local clinic for health check**
Register with a family doctor (kakaritsuke-i) near your home.



PHASE 6

First 3 Months: Administration

- ☐ **Collect My Number Card**
Bring notification letter + ID to ward office.
- ☐ **Convert driving license (if applicable)**
At JAF center. Bring JP license translation + original. 3-6 months wait.
- ☐ **Register for e-Tax (online tax portal)**
Required for annual tax return in March. nta.go.jp portal.
- ☐ **Update bank account with My Number**
Required by law. Do it at your branch or app.



PHASE 7

Ongoing: Stay Compliant

- ☐ **File annual tax return (kakutei shinkoku)**
Due by March 15. Required if income exceeds 2M JPY/year or multiple sources.
- ☐ **Renew Residence Card before expiry**
Check expiry date. Apply 3 months before at Immigration Services Agency.
- ☐ **Update address after any move**
Within 14 days at ward office. Also update bank, NHI, pension.
- ☐ **Review your visa renewal timeline**
Many visas: 1-3 year terms. Plan renewals 6 months in advance.

TokyoExpat

Your relocation guide for life in Japan

Need personalized advice?

Every relocation is different. Book a 1-on-1 consultation to get answers tailored to your visa situation, timeline, and budget.



1h Consultation

Visa, housing, admin —
answered for your
situation



Step-by-step PDF guides
for every stage of your
move

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